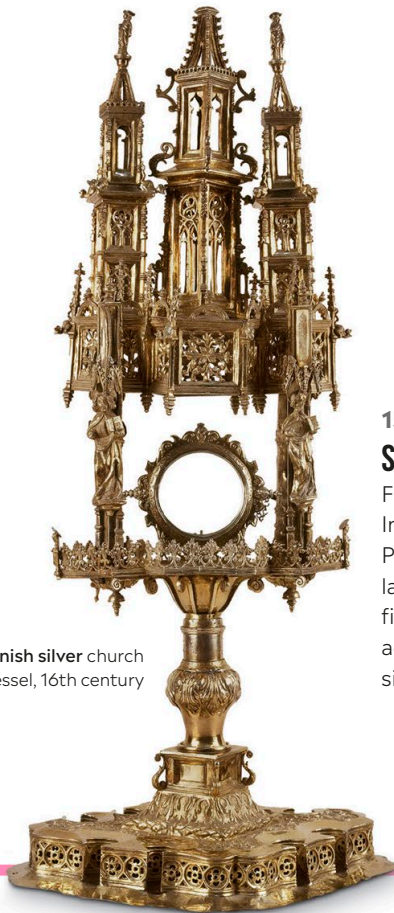


Spanish mines in the Americas produced 40,000 tons of silver in two centuries

▷ **Spanish silver** church vessel, 16th century



1545

SOUTH AMERICAN SILVER

From 1532, Spanish Conquistadores took over the Inca Empire. In 1545 they discovered the world's richest deposits of silver at Potosi, in what is now Bolivia. Exploited with ruthless use of forced labour, the mines brought the Spanish monarchy untold wealth, financing armies that dominated Europe. Silver was also carried across the Pacific to Ming China, where it paid for goods such as silk and ceramics.

1552 Tsar Ivan the Terrible defeats the Khanate of Kazan and expands Russia into Siberia

1559

1552 China grants Portuguese traders an offshore base at Macao

1556

AKBAR THE GREAT RULES INDIA

Ruling from 1556 to 1605, Akbar was the greatest of India's Mughal emperors. Tripling the extent of the empire so that it covered much of the subcontinent, he followed a policy of religious tolerance, actively seeking the support of non-Muslim Indians for his Muslim regime. He gave the diverse empire a unified administration and used the wealth from taxation to patronize artists, architects, and scholars.



△ Gold coin of Akbar

△ **Akbar**, Shah Jahan Album, c.1630

